

Building A Better Web Site

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Most SoHo businesses today need to have a Web presence, especially given the increasing number of searches for products and solutions being conducted online. The days of consulting the Yellow Pages are almost gone, at least in every city or town that's been Net-enabled for the past two years.

Previously, in this space, we've shown you how you can set up a very basic HTML-based Web site—at almost no cost. Now, for you to take your Web site to the next level, and start creating a true online presence, you need to get into the world of scripted Web pages, and things such as server-side scripting to create dynamic Web pages that will give your site the professional look it needs.

This is where coding languages such as Microsoft's ASP (Active Server Pages) and PHP (PHP: Hypertext Preprocessor) come in. However, it's not something that

just anyone can sit down and learn overnight. For the SoHo segment, or even for a personal Web site, hiring a few site developers to build your site is also not an option. What next, then?

Nuke 'em

PHP, the open source alternative to Microsoft's ASP, is the obvious choice to build a Web site. Why? Because it is cross-platform—a PHP site can be hosted on any Web server, running any OS, unlike ASP, which needs a Microsoft OS—and because it's open source.

The biggest advantage of open source software is the thousands of developers who dedicate time to improve or simplify such software.

PHP-Nuke is a project by dedicated developers who decided that people shouldn't need to know how to code in order to develop their own PHP-based Web sites.

There are many offshoots of PHP-Nuke, which is the beauty of open source, and these are listed in the box "Options". The installation and control panel of each do not logically differ much from PHP-Nuke, so you can feel free to experiment with some of them as well.

Here, however, we will stick to PHP-Nuke, and learn how to install, configure, and finally, tweak it to give you a Web site that's unique and looks exactly what you want it to look like.

Prerequisites

There are some things you will need to have in place before you can begin setting up your site, such as a domain name and hosting space on a Web server that supports PHP and MySQL databases. Both are relatively easy to find.

When it comes to Web sites, HTML can be limiting. Learn how PHP can expand the possibilities